REVIEW

The Conversation Continues: Liberalism and the Conservatism

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Political conservatives have much to thank political liberals for. For a conservative reader, this statement may appear perplexing, given that political conservatism and political liberalism have spent more than two centuries criticising one another. From the conservative perspective, political liberalism has been the source of numerous misguided projects of salvation that have inflicted considerable damage on Western societies. Meanwhile, political liberals have often criticised conservatives for resisting the tide of progress that, in their view, would lead towards a better and more perfect society. In politics, liberalism relies on hope: the belief that progress and a better future remain within humanity's reach. Political conservatism, by contrast, confronted with the wreckage left by liberal projects, relies on the familiar to pick up the pieces.

Nevertheless, political conservatives do have much to thank political liberals for, since without the project of the French Revolution, political conservatism would not have emerged as a self-conscious political doctrine. It was through Edmund Burke's response to the Revolution that political conservatism developed as a distinct doctrine, drawing upon the broader tradition of Western thought to articulate a critique of what he understood as its wrongs and excesses. Hence, since that event, political conservatives and liberals have been friends, rivals, and enemies within the great conversation of politics.

The relationship of friendship, rivalry, and enmity between conservatism and liberalism has often attracted scholarly attention. However, in our current age, in which liberal hegemony is being questioned intellectually and politically by more radical and reactionary forces, this relationship has become a catalyst for an expanding body of scholarship on conservatism, liberalism, and their interaction. One of the latest additions is *The Conservative Critique of Liberalism*, a collection of chapters by various scholars edited by David McGrogan and Martin Beckstein. The volume has much to offer historians of political thought, legal theorists, political theorists, and scholars of public policy. Yet its contributions are, at times, overshadowed by the breadth of subjects covered, whose connections are not always apparent without returning to the introduction; by moments when this reviewer found himself wanting more; and by occasional misunderstandings.

McGrogan and Beckstein begin the book by noting, correctly, that 'conservatism itself is a concept that receives surprisingly little academic attention' (p. 2). The reasons they highlight are the often-blurred connection between liberalism and conservatism, as well as conservatism's reluctance to construct a systematic philosophy of its own. Yet scholarly attention to conservatism is growing, and this book itself provides evidence of that development. The reasons for this growth are explored in Claudia Franziska

Brühwiler's chapter, in which she examines the collapse of the conservative movement consensus in the American context due to the emergence and growth of post-liberalism and national conservatism.

It is easy for a political movement composed of distinct factions to maintain consensus when there is a unifying threat that brings them together. In the case of the American conservative movement, it was the threat of Soviet communism and the growth of collectivism that fostered such consensus. Yet, once these threats had receded, the broad coalition that constituted the American conservative movement began to collapse. This collapse, made visible by Trump's electoral victory in 2016, leads Brühwiler to argue that '[t]wo sub-movements have emerged as contenders to lead a renewed conservative movement, if not a new consensus: postliberals and national conservatives are among the loudest critics of the 'old' consensus and the past trajectory of US conservatism' (p. 61).

These two sub-movements are united by their virulent anti-liberalism and deep critique of the post-war American conservative movement. However, as Brühwiler (p. 66) notes, they 'are united in what they are against—but not yet following the same path'. This highlights the distinct trajectories pursued by post-liberals and national conservatives in relation to their agendas and policy preferences. More importantly, a point that I hoped Brühwiler would have explored in greater detail is that, even within post-liberalism and national conservatism in the United States, there are profound disagreements for example over religion, economics, and the extent to which state power should be employed.

While an exploration of these internal disagreements may have fallen outside the scope of the chapter, it would have added further force to Brühwiler's conclusion: namely, that these sub-movements and 'their ideas preclude them from being part of or lead conservatives towards a new consensus', and hence that these movements 'do not offer anything that would draw in the scattered members of the conservative family' (pp. 68-69). Brühwiler supports this conclusion by noting that the political actor most referenced by post-liberals and national conservatives is not Donald Trump, but rather Viktor Orbán's leadership and political agenda. Ironically, the figure most frequently referenced by these sub-movements is a leader far removed from the realities of American politics and one who was recently removed from office by the electorate. In the end, Brühwiler raises an important question: if these movements cannot provide a new consensus, can other conservative movements accommodate them within a renewed consensus? In this reviewer's estimation, this is certainly a long shot, and perhaps even impossible; nevertheless, it is an endeavour that conservatives cannot avoid.

Perhaps the ideas for a new consensus can find inspiration abroad. Readers can discover such ideas, and learn much about this tradition if unfamiliar with it, in two excellent chapters that explore German conservatism. The first, by Laura Achtelstetter and Alexander Kruska, examines the attempts of Prussian Old Conservatives to 'develop a set of ideas that allowed them to reconcile the demands for political freedom with their anti-revolutionary stance'—in other words, how to live with liberalism (p. 23). These Prussian conservatives therefore sought to construct a "true liberalism" anchored in a natural, God-given order that made "true liberty" possible while allowing for gradual reform. This stood in opposition to a "false liberalism" based on erroneous presuppositions that promoted a "false liberty" and would lead to the upheaval and horrors of the French Revolution. In short, we find in these Prussian conservatives 'a meaningful counternarrative to the liberal focus on individual autonomy and human-centred governance', but one that could not escape confronting, and even accepting, some of the realities brought about by liberalism (p. 34).

The second chapter examines Gerd-Klaus Kaltenbrunner and is written by Tobias Aler-Bartels, who explores Kaltenbrunner's attempts to construct a new conservatism in 1970s Germany. The chapter provides an excellent intellectual overview of the state of conservatism in both pre- and post-1945 Germany. The radical forms of German conservatism discredited themselves through their proximity to National Socialism; hence, post-war German conservatism experienced a '"Westernization of German Conservatives"' [as] a direct response to the radicalisation of the ideology. However, the recourse to the "Western" tradition of conservative thought…continued to be a striking manifestation of an identity crisis

of German conservatism after 1945' (p. 44). Despite this movement towards a more liberal conservatism, 'conservatism was [still] divided into largely irreconcilable factions' (p. 45).

In Kaltenbrunner's case, a new conservatism was needed for the post-liberal age: one that 'had to gain a certain distance from his own tradition and opt for many a "radical intervention in the status quo"' (p. 52). For Kaltenbrunner, this radical intervention would not be found within the Western traditions of conservative thought, but rather in a return to the traditions of German radical conservatism. In short, like contemporary post-liberals and other radical elements on the Right, Kaltenbrunner sought to overcome the perceived evils of liberal rationalism by adopting a rationalism with a more acceptable face. Aler-Bartels reaches much the same conclusion as Brühwiler: this turn towards the radical represents a dead end. As Aler-Bartels writes of Kaltenbrunner's radical conservatism, 'as liberal and moderate conservatives became increasingly self-confident…radical conservative metapolitics failed to find a lasting resonance in the targeted circles' (p. 56).

Conceivably, insights for a new consensus can be found in the Anglo-American tradition. This theme is explored in Kieron O'Hara's chapter, which seeks to construct a conservative approach to privacy 'that eschews liberal arguments and, instead, rest[s] on (Burkean) conservative foundations' (p. 89). While liberals have approached privacy, often in highly contested ways, through the ideals of autonomy, individuality, and freedom, O'Hara argues that, in an age of digital modernity that threatens privacy and individuality, the conservative approach 'would focus on the existence and durability of modernity, whose very longevity is evidence of its social value', thereby providing a more secure foundation (p. 119). O'Hara finds the Burkean conservative thinker who provides the conceptual tools and framework for this defence in the work of Michael Oakeshott.

O'Hara makes an interesting and necessary argument for a conservative approach. However, by recruiting Michael Oakeshott for this task, the argument begins to encounter difficulties. First, O'Hara presents Oakeshott as a Burkean conservative. This is problematic because Oakeshott himself rejected this label. This is not to suggest that Oakeshott and Burke did not share conservative sympathies; rather, Oakeshott belongs to a secular and sceptical tradition, whereas Burke does not. As Oakeshott (1962, p. 195) tells us, 'in my opinion, there is more to be learnt about this [conservative] disposition from Montaigne, Pascal, Hobbes and Hume than from Burke or Bentham'.

The second problem is that O'Hara does not appear to fully understand Oakeshott's position, which is surprising given his longstanding interest in Oakeshott's thought. For example, we are told that 'individuality is not valuable on its own terms, but rather because it is part of the tradition into which we have been socialised' (p. 118). The implication is that O'Hara interprets Oakeshott as valuing individuality in instrumental terms. This, however, represents a misunderstanding of Oakeshott's thought. When Oakeshott writes about the individual, he does so in intrinsic rather than instrumental terms, emphasising the uniqueness of each person rather than valuing individuality merely because it forms part of an enduring tradition. Indeed, Oakeshott (1962, p. 244), referring to friendship and human love, writes:

> Its object is individual and not concretion of qualities: it was for Adonis that Venus quit heaven. What is communicated and enjoyed is not an array of emotions—affection, tenderness, concern, fear, relation, etc.—but the uniqueness of a self.

These are not the words of an instrumentalist, as O'Hara's interpretation implies, but of someone who attributed a much deeper intrinsic value to individuality. O'Hara's instrumentalist reading of Oakeshott is not confined to the question of individuality; it also extends to his understanding of tradition. Here again, we encounter what I believe to be a misreading. Oakeshott did not regard traditions as goal-oriented or instrumentally valuable. Rather, he understood them as practices in which individuals participate and from which they derive meaningful satisfaction. As Oakeshott (2001, pp. 64-65) writes:

> Being human is recognizing oneself to be related to others, not as parts of an organism are related, nor as members of a single, all-inclusive "society," but in virtue of participation in multiple understood relationships and in the enjoyment of understood, historic languages of feelings, sentiments, imaginings, fancies, desires, recognitions, moral and religious beliefs, intellectual and practical enterprises, customs, conventions, procedures and practices, canons, maxims and principles of conduct, rules which denote obligations and offices which specify duties… a human being is the inhabitant of a world composed, not of "things," but of meanings; that is, of occurrences in some manner recognized, identified, understood and responded to in terms of this understanding. It is a world of sentiments and beliefs, and it includes also human artifacts…for these, also, are "expressions" which have meanings and which require to be understood in order to be used or enjoyed. To be without this understanding is to be, not a human being, but a stranger to a human condition.

Again, these are not the words of an instrumentalist, but rather of someone who advances a non-instrumental understanding of tradition. Nevertheless, O'Hara raises an interesting question concerning how Oakeshott's understanding of the role of the state might provide insights into the challenges posed by digital modernity. However, as O'Hara himself acknowledges, significant difficulties remain, since the private platforms that dominate digital modernity are not analogous to the modern state. Indeed, Oakeshott was not a minimalist with regard to government, as his essay 'The Political Economy of Freedom' reminds us. There is, therefore, scope within his thought for government intervention in relation to private actors. Yet, as O'Hara correctly observes, important questions remain: how can such intervention avoid becoming paternalistic? Does government possess the expertise necessary to regulate these platforms effectively? And how should it respond to rapid technological innovation? There are no easy answers to these questions. An Oakeshottian response may have fallen outside the scope of the chapter, but it is one that I had hoped O'Hara would explore in the future.

The themes raised by O'Hara are taken up, albeit from a different perspective, in Richard Mullender's chapter on the conservative liberalism of Ronald Dworkin. Although Mullender is quick to point out that both readers of Dworkin and Dworkin himself regarded him as a liberal, 'there are grounds on which to argue that Dworkin's contributions to jurisprudence and political philosophy exhibit a conservative dimension' (p. 159). To develop this argument, Mullender employs Ralph Waldo Emerson's essay 'The Conservative', with its characterisation of conservatism as the party of memory and liberalism as the party of hope, as a framework for identifying the conservative disposition within Dworkin's thought. This disposition is expressed in Dworkin's idea of "fit", whereby 'the judge applies to the dispute must cohere with existing law' and institutional history when deciding hard cases (p. 169). In short, Mullender finds within Dworkin 'a combination of "memory" and "hope"', lending support to the conclusion that 'his contributions to legal and political philosophy are a liberal-cum-conservative admixture' (p. 183).

That Dworkin exhibits the conservative disposition is unsurprising, since the conservative disposition is not the exclusive preserve of political conservatism. Indeed, the late philosopher G. A. Cohen also claimed this disposition, and he was hardly a political conservative. What Mullender's chapter reminds us is that the conservative disposition is inherent in every human being, since each individual has at least one aspect of life in which they prefer the familiar to the unfamiliar. This may be described as a form of natural conservatism. Yet, while Dworkin may draw upon the conservative disposition, he does not ultimately apply it to politics. Indeed, Dworkin may make use of memory, but ultimately it is instrumental to the achievement of the ideal state he hopes to realise. Consequently, hope ultimately overwhelms memory. The memory that is subordinated is that embodied in the formal and authoritative procedures of the rule of law, sacrificed in pursuit of preferred moral and political ends.

That Dworkin exhibits natural conservatism is the main difficulty raised by Beckstein and McGrogan's introduction: namely, the contested nature of the concept of conservatism itself. Indeed, there is no universally accepted definition of conservatism, nor is there an agreed taxonomy capable of clearly delineating its

various forms. In their introduction, Beckstein and McGrogan attempt to provide such a taxonomy by distinguishing between substantive and procedural conservatism. Yet this taxonomy appears rather limited. For example, natural conservatism is not considered. Moreover, thinkers grouped within these categories often differ in significant respects, suggesting the need for a more nuanced taxonomy. Ironically, their taxonomy of liberalism is considerably more differentiated, distinguishing between classical, social, neo-, and progressive liberalism.

Nevertheless, despite the limited taxonomy of conservatism provided by Beckstein and McGrogan, the diverse topics and approaches adopted by the contributors reflect the richness of conservative thought and the variety of conservative traditions, particularly in relation to their complex relationship with liberalism. It is precisely in this richness and diversity of contributions, which also constitutes a weakness, that the value of the volume comes to the fore. Indeed, David Campbell and Kevin Dowd's chapter on the UK Government's response to the COVID-19 pandemic reads, at times, somewhat out of place within the volume. However, it ultimately demonstrates the classic conservative critique of the dangers when scientific knowledge is translated into political practice in pursuit of salvation. Their chapter is a stark reminder of the enduring value of political conservatism within the great conversation of politics.

In the end, *The Conservative Critique of Liberalism* and the wider project behind it—the International Research Network on Critical Theory and Conservative Thought—offer scholars a unique opportunity to explore the possibility of dialogue between critical theory and conservative thought, despite their apparent incompatibility. This endeavour alone makes the project and the book innovative, interesting, and worthwhile. For this Oakeshottian reviewer, however, the project appears to be a folly, since the core axioms of critical theory and conservative thought are fundamentally opposed and ultimately irreconcilable. Nevertheless, one of the defining characteristics of the academic world is its tradition of disinterested scholarship in pursuit of truth. This volume is an admirable contribution to that tradition.

REFERENCES

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